

Word-count declaration

Manuscript: *A Comparability Protocol for Benchmarking Relational Database Access Layers in Express.js* (submission build `ist_main.tex`).

The official IST journal policy confirms a **15,000-word maximum for research papers**. The current author guidance supplied with this revision additionally assigns **200 words to each figure or table** and counts references and manuscript appendices. This declaration uses a deliberately conservative implementation of that rule.

Component
Seven body sections (<code>texcount</code> sum, including section headings and caption text encountered in those files)
Structured abstract (<code>texcount</code> sum)
Remaining front matter and required declarations (title/keywords, CRediT, competing interest, data availability statement)
Main-text tables and figures (7×200)
Rendered reference list (65 entries; conservative <code>pdftotext</code> count including the heading and page folios)
Conservative IST submission equivalent

The controlling total is therefore **14,783 words**, leaving **217 words of headroom** under the 15,000-word limit. The structured abstract contains 222 prose words (227 under the `texcount` sum convention), below 300 words.

The body grew by 996 words against the previous declaration, principally the new Study Design subsection documenting AI-assisted research tooling, which current publisher policy requires to appear in the Methods section. Front matter fell by 73 words because the former back-matter research-software declaration was reduced to a cross-reference. To keep the total within the limit the additions were tightened and one redundancy removed: the residual left open by the unsatisfied implementation-review stage had come to be argued in three sections and is now argued once, in Threats, with cross-references elsewhere.

This total is intentionally stricter than a research-content-only count. It includes all required declaration text even though such text is commonly treated as submission metadata. It also retains caption words already encountered by `texcount` and then assigns the full 200-word allowance to every rendered float, so it does not undercount captions. The paper has no manuscript appendices. The separately submitted `supplement.pdf` is online supplementary material, not an appendix embedded in the research paper.

Reproduction commands:

```
sh cd paper/ist texcount -sum -brief ../sections/introduction.tex ../sections/related_work.tex
../sections/methodology.tex ../sections/results.tex ../sections/discussion.tex ../sections/threats.tex
../sections/conclusion.tex sed -n "43,68p" ist_main.tex | texcount -sum -brief - texcount
-inc -sum ist_main.tex rg -c "^\\{\\}\\bibitem" ist_main.bbl rg -F "\\{\\}\\@writefile{lot}"
ist_main.aux rg -F "\\{\\}\\@writefile{lof}" ist_main.aux pdftotext ist_main.pdf - |
sed -n "/^References$/,\$p" | wc -w
```

Count date: 26 July 2026. Any later prose or float change requires this declaration to be regenerated.